Love and the Search for Beauty and Goodness—the Symposium

Reading the Platonic dialogues we gain a general impression of how Socrates (469–399 BCE) did philosophy. He was interested in moral issues and philosophized neither by giving lectures nor by writing treatises, but by talking with other people. Socrates examined the views of his interlocutors by means of questions and answers to look into the logical coherence of the proposed views. A defining feature of this examination is that at every step Socrates tried to base the investigation on a point agreed by both discussing parties. Since *dialogue* is the way by which Socrates practiced philosophy, his method is known as *dialectic*.

The themes of *Symposium* are love and the search for beauty and goodness, all of which are central to Plato's philosophy as well as to our lives. In the dialogue we gain a grasp of Socrates' method of questioning and a valuable insight into Plato's theory of Ideas. The whole dialogue is written in a mostly non-technical language with dramatic scenes and witty exchanges of words, and not the least the speech of Alcibiades provides us with a vivid and compelling image of Socrates.

The dialogue is placed in 416 BCE when Agathon's tragedy won the prize at a drama festival. The topic of the drinking party is Eros (the god of love). There are six speakers, each giving a eulogy of the god of love. Each of them tries to surpass the previous one by adding new perspectives in his speech. The drinking party opens with the praises of pederasty (love of boys) by Phaedrus and Pausanias, which are followed by Eryximachus' identification of Eros as a universal force and Aristophanes' characterization of the god as man's natural urge for wholeness. Then it is Agathon's turn to give an impressive speech extolling Eros to the skies. The contest culminates in Socrates' recalling the teachings of Diotima, the priestess of Mantinea who revealed the real nature of Eros. Eros embodies man's search for beauty and goodness, which is illustrated in the "ladder of love." The ascent begins with the attraction to individual physical beauty, but ends in the attainment of eternal beauty itself, which is the ultimate object of the search for beauty and

the origin of all beautiful things in this world. The ladder is an ascent from the ever-changing world of phenomena to the ever-lasting world of Ideas. Only in this latter realm can we find the foundation of our moral behaviour and the knowledge of moral matters.

The party ends with the burst-in of Alcibiades, a young general and vehement lover of Socrates. For Alcibiades, Socrates is an eccentric lover. In his drunken praise of Socrates, Alcibiades gives us a portrait of Socrates' unique abilities, extraordinary personality and passion for philosophy. We may ask ourselves how this can be related to the image of philosopher—literally "lover of wisdom"—which Diotima presents to us in her speech.

In the dialogue we are told that love is not confined to physical beauty, but plays an essential role in the pursuit of moral beauty and goodness. The *Symposium* invites us to reflect on our own idea of love; it also spurs us to contemplate Socrates' attitude towards philosophy: it is not just about abstract ideas and rational arguments, but the key to a good and happy life.

The following translation of the *Symposium* is by Tom Griffith from *Plato: Symposium and the Death of Socrates*. It is chosen for its use of the modern colloquium and for the ease with which it captures the humour and spontaneity of the lively exchanges among the characters.

The pagination given in the margins is that of the Stephanus edition of Plato's complete works in 1578, e.g. 172b means column b on page 172 in this edition.

Ho Wai-ming

Symposium

by Plato

THE SPEAKERS IN THE DIALOGUE

AGATHON	a writer of tragedies	/ˈægəθɒn/
SOCRATES	a truth-loving eccentric	/ˈsɒkrətiːz/
PHAEDRUS	an idealist	/ˈfiːdrəz/
PAUSANIAS	a realist — Agathon's lover	/pɔːˈseɪnɪəz/
ARISTOPHANES	a writer of comedies	/ˌærɪˈstɒfəniːz/
ERYXIMACHUS	a doctor	/ˌerɪˈsɪmɑːkəz/
ALCIBIADES	a politician and playboy	/ˌælsɪˈbaɪədiːz/

From Plato, *Symposium and The Death of Socrates*, translated by Tom Griffith. Published by Wordsworth Editions Ltd 1997.
© Tom Griffith 1997. Reprinted by permission of Tom Griffith and Wordsworth Editions Limited. All rights reserved.

PROLOGUE — APOLLODORUS AND A FRIEND

172 APOLLODORUS You couldn't have asked anyone better. I live in Phalerum, and the day before yesterday I was going up to town when a man I know caught sight of me disappearing in the distance. He gave me a shout, calling me (a little facetiously) "You there! Citizen of Phalerum! Hey, Apollodorus! Wait a moment."

So I stopped and waited.

"Apollodorus," he said, "I've been looking for you for ages. I wanted to ask you about the time when Agathon and Socrates and Alcibiades and the others all
b met for dinner. I want to know what was said about love. I was told about it by a man who had talked to Phoenix, son of Philippus; he said you knew about it as well. He wasn't much help—couldn't remember anything very definite. Can you give me your version? After all, who better than you to talk about Socrates' conversations? For instance, were you at the dinner-party yourself, or not?"

"You must have been given a pretty garbled account, if you think the party
c you're asking about took place recently enough for me to have been at it."

"Oh! I thought you were."

"Really, Glaucon, how could I have been? It's ages since Agathon last lived in Athens, and less than three years since I became friends with Socrates, and got into the habit of keeping up with what he says and does every day. Before that my
173 life was just a random whirl of activity. I thought I was extremely busy, but in fact I was the most pathetic creature imaginable, just as you are now, doing anything to avoid philosophical thought."

"Very funny. When *did* the party happen, then?"

"It was when we were still children, when Agathon won the prize with his first tragedy, the day after he and the members of the chorus made the usual winners' thanksgivings."

"Oh, I see. It *was* a long time ago, then. Who told you about it? Was it Socrates himself?"

b "God, no. I got it from the man who told Phoenix, a man called Aristodemus, from Cydathenaeum. Small man, never wears shoes. He'd been at the party; in fact, I think he must have been one of Socrates' keenest admirers in those days. But I've

also asked Socrates about some of the things he told me, and his version agreed with Aristodemus'."

"You must tell me all about it, and walking into town is an ideal opportunity. You can talk, and I will listen."

So we discussed the party as we went along, and that's why, as I said c
originally, I'm a good person to ask about it. And if I've got to tell it to you as well, I'd better get on with it. In any case, I get tremendous pleasure out of talking about philosophy myself, or listening to other people talk about it, quite apart from thinking it's good for me. Other conversation, especially your kind, about money or business, bores me stiff. You're my friends, but I feel sorry for you, because you think you're getting somewhere, when you're not. You in turn probably think me d
misguided, and you may well be right. However, I don't *think* you are misguided; I know for certain you are.

FRIEND Still the old Apollodorus we know and love. Never a good word for yourself or anyone else. As far as I can see, you regard absolutely everyone, starting with yourself, as a lost cause—except for Socrates, that is. I don't know where you picked up the nickname "softy"; it certainly doesn't fit your conversation—always full of fury against yourself, and everyone else apart from Socrates.

APOLLODORUS And if that's my opinion of myself and the rest of you, then e
obviously I'm crazy, or mistaken, I suppose.

FRIEND Let's not argue about that now, Apollodorus, just do as I ask, and tell me what was said at Agathon's party.

APOLLODORUS The conversation went something like this . . . or better, let me 174
try to tell it to you right from the beginning, as Aristodemus told it to me.

ARISTODEMUS' ACCOUNT

I met Socrates, all washed and brushed, and wearing shoes (a thing he hardly ever did). I asked him where he was going looking so elegant.

"I'm going to dinner with Agathon. I avoided the first celebration last night; I couldn't face the crowd. But I said I'd come this evening. I'm looking elegant,
b because Agathon always looks elegant. What about you? How do you feel about coming to dinner uninvited?"

"I'll do anything you tell me."

"Come on then. Let's ignore the proverb, 'good men come uninvited to lesser men's feasts', or rather let's change it, to 'good men come uninvited to Agathon's feast'. After all, Homer does worse than ignore it; he completely contradicts it. His Agamemnon is an outstanding warrior, while his Menelaus is a man of straw. But
c when Agamemnon is sacrificing and feasting Homer lets Menelaus come to the feast without an invitation, though that's a case of a lesser man coming to dinner with a better."

"I'm afraid, in my case, that Homer is likely to be nearer the mark than you, Socrates. It'll be a question of a nonentity coming to dinner uninvited with a wise man. You'd better decide what you'll say if you do take me. I'm not coming
d uninvited—only as your guest."

"Two heads are better than one. We'll think of something to say. Come on."

So off we went. But Socrates, absorbed in his own thoughts, got left behind on the way. I was going to wait for him, but he told me to go on ahead. So I turned
e up at Agathon's house by myself, and found the door open. In fact, it was slightly embarrassing, because one of the house-slaves met me, and took me straight in, where I found the others had just sat down to dinner. Agathon saw me come in, and at once said, "Aristodemus, you're just in time to have dinner with us. I hope that's what you've come for. If not, it'll have to wait for another time. I tried to get hold of you yesterday, to ask you, but couldn't find you. How come you haven't brought Socrates with you?"

I turned round and looked behind me, and couldn't see Socrates anywhere. So I explained that I had come with Socrates. In fact, but for his invitation, I wouldn't have come at all.

"I'm glad you did. But where is he?"

175 "He was right behind me just now. I've no more idea than you where he could have got to."

Agathon turned to a slave. "Could you go and look for Socrates, please, and ask him in? Aristodemus, why don't you sit over there by Eryximachus?"

While one slave was giving me a wash, so I could sit down to dinner, another slave came in: "That Socrates you asked me to look for has gone wandering up to the front door of the wrong house. He's just standing there. I asked him to come in but he won't."

"How odd. Still, don't give up. Keep on asking him."

But I said, "No, leave him alone. He's always doing this. It doesn't matter b
where he is. He just wanders off and stands there. I don't think he'll be long. Don't badger him; just leave him."

"Well, if you say so, I suppose we'd better." He turned to the slaves. "The rest of us will eat now. Serve the meal just as you like. No one's going to tell you how to do it, any more than I ever tell you. Imagine we're all your guests, and try to give e
us a meal we'll enjoy."

So we started having dinner, though still no sign of Socrates. Agathon kept wanting to send people to look for him, but I wouldn't let him. When he did turn up, he hadn't been long by his standards, but even so we were about halfway through dinner. Agathon, who'd sat down last, at a table on his own, said "Come and sit next to me, Socrates. Then perhaps I shall absorb whatever it was you were thinking d
about outside. You must have found the answer, or you wouldn't have come in to join us."

Socrates sat down. "Wouldn't it be marvellous, Agathon," he said, "if ideas were the kind of things which could be imparted simply by contact, and those of us who had few could absorb them from those who had a lot in the same sort of way that liquid can flow from a full container to an empty one if you put a piece of string between them? If that's the nature of ideas, then I think I'm lucky to be sitting next to you, and getting a nice, substantial transfusion. My ideas aren't much e
use. They have an ambiguous, dreamlike quality, whereas yours are brilliant, and with so much scope for further improvement. You're only young, and yet they were particularly brilliant the day before yesterday, as more than thirty thousand Greeks can testify."

"Don't be sarcastic, Socrates. And let's settle this question of ideas a bit later. We'll give Dionysus the casting vote, but you'd better have dinner first."

So Socrates sat down and ate, with the others. We poured offerings, sang 176
hymns, and did all the usual things. Then our thoughts turned to drinking, and Pausanias made a suggestion. "Well, gentlemen, how can we make things as painless

for ourselves as possible? I must admit to feeling rather frail after yesterday evening. I need a breather, and I expect most of you do, too. After all, you were there as well.
b So, how can we make our drinking as painless as possible?"

ARISTOPHANES I couldn't agree more, Pausanias. Whatever else we do, we don't want to let ourselves in for another evening's hard drinking. I'm one of those who sank without trace last night.

ERYXIMACHUS I'm glad you both feel like that. But we ought also to consider how strong Agathon is feeling.

AGATHON Not at all strong.

c ERYXIMACHUS It would certainly be a stroke of luck for people like Aristodemus and Phaedrus and me, if you hard drinkers are prepared to take an evening off. We're not in your league. I'm not worried about Socrates—he's equally happy either way, so he won't mind what we do. But as far as I can see, no one here is all that keen on drinking a lot, so perhaps I can tell you the truth about getting drunk without causing too much offence. My experience as a doctor leaves me in no doubt
d that getting drunk is bad for you. I'm not keen on drinking to excess myself, and I wouldn't advise anyone else to, especially anyone who still had a hangover from yesterday.

PHAEDRUS Well, I generally follow your advice, especially on medical matters. So will the others, if they have any sense.

e So we all agreed just to drink what we felt like, rather than treating it as an opportunity to get drunk.

ERYXIMACHUS Good, that's settled then. We'll all drink as much as we feel like, and there's no compulsion on anyone. And since we've got that sorted out, I've another suggestion to make. I don't think we need this flute girl who's just started playing. She can play to herself, or to the women upstairs, if she feels like it, but for this evening I suggest *we* stick to conversation. And I've an idea what we might talk about, if you want to hear it.

Everyone said they did want to hear it, and urged him to make his suggestion. 177

ERYXIMACHUS Well, it arises out of Euripides' *Melanippe*. And it isn't really my idea. It's Phaedrus'. He gets quite worked up about it. "Don't you think it's odd, Eryximachus," he says, "that most of the other gods have had hymns and songs of praise written to them by the poets, but never a word in praise of Eros, the oldest b and greatest god? And it's not for want of good poets, either. Or think of the great teachers—they've recorded the exploits of Heracles and other heroes, in prose. Prodicus, for example, does that sort of thing beautifully. Now maybe that's not very surprising, but I came across a book the other day, by a well-known writer, with an extraordinary eulogy in it on the value of salt. You can find any number of things singled out for praise in this way. What is surprising is that there should be c so much enthusiasm for that kind of thing, and yet no one, up to the present day, has ever found himself able to praise Eros as he deserves. He is a remarkable god, but he has been totally neglected."

I agree with Phaedrus. I'd like to do him a favour and make my contribution. What's more, the present gathering seems an ideal opportunity to praise the god. So, if you agree, we can quite happily spend our time in talk. I propose that each d of us in turn, going round anticlockwise, should make a speech, the best he can, in praise of Eros. Phaedrus can start, since he is in the position of honour, and since the whole thing was his idea.

SOCRATES I don't think anyone will vote against you, Eryximachus. I'm certainly not going to refuse, since love is the only thing I ever claim to know anything about. Agathon and Pausanias won't mind—still less Aristophanes, since his only e interests in life are Dionysus and Aphrodite. In fact I can't see anyone here who *will* object. It's a little unfair on those of us sitting here in the last positions. Still, if you first speakers speak well enough, we shan't have to worry. Good luck, Phaedrus. You go first, and make your speech in praise of Eros.

They all agreed with Socrates, and told Phaedrus to start. Aristodemus couldn't 178 remember the exact details of everybody's speech, nor in turn can I remember precisely what he said. But I can give you the gist of those speeches and speakers which were most worth remembering.

Phaedrus, as I said, began—something like this.

PHAEDRUS

Eros is a great god, a marvel to men and gods alike. This is true in many ways, and it is especially true of his birth. He is entitled to our respect, as the oldest of the gods—
b as I can prove. Eros has no parents, either in reality or in works of prose and poetry. Take Hesiod, for example. All he says is that in the beginning there was Chaos. ". . . and then came the full-breasted Earth, the eternal and immovable foundation of everything, and Eros." Acusilaus agrees with Hesiod, that after Chaos there were just these two, Earth and Eros. And then there's Parmenides' theory about his birth, that "Eros was created first of the Gods." So there is widespread agreement that Eros
c is of great antiquity. And being very old he also brings us very great benefits. I can see nothing better in life for a young boy, as soon as he is old enough, than finding a good lover, nor for a lover than finding a boyfriend. Love, more than anything (more than family, or position, or wealth), implants in men the thing which must
d be their guide if they are to live a good life. And what is that? It is a horror of what is degrading, and a passionate desire for what is good. These qualities are essential if a state or an individual is to accomplish anything great or good. Imagine a man in love being found out doing something humiliating, or letting someone else do something degrading to him, because he was too cowardly to stop it. It would embarrass him more to be found out by the boy he loved than by his father or his friends, or anyone. And you can see just the same thing happening with the boy.
e He is more worried about being caught behaving badly by his admirers than by anyone else. So if there were some way of arranging that a state, or an army, could be made up entirely of pairs of lovers, it is impossible to imagine a finer population.
179 They would avoid all dishonour, and compete with one another for glory: in battle, this kind of army, though small, fighting side by side could conquer virtually the whole world. After all, a lover would sooner be seen by anyone deserting his post or throwing away his weapons, rather than by his boyfriend. He would normally choose to die many times over instead. And as for abandoning the boy, or not trying to save him if he is in danger—no one is such a coward as not to be inspired with
b courage by Eros, making him the equal of the naturally brave man. Homer says, and rightly, that god breathes fire into some of his heroes. And it is just this quality, whose origin is to be found within himself, that Eros imparts to lovers.

What is more, lovers are the only people prepared to die for others. Not just men, either; women also sometimes. A good example is Alcestis, the daughter of Pelias. She alone was willing to die for her husband. He had a father and mother c
but she so far surpassed them in devotion, because of her passion for him, that she showed them to be strangers to their son, relations in name only. In so doing she was thought, by men and gods alike, to have performed a deed of supreme excellence. Indeed the gods were so pleased with her action that they brought her soul back from the underworld—a privilege they granted to only a fortunate handful of the many people who have done good deeds. That shows how highly d
even the gods value loyalty and courage in love. Orpheus, the son of Oeagrus, on the other hand, was sent away from the underworld empty-handed; he was shown a mere phantom of the woman he came to find, and not given the woman herself. Of course Orpheus was a musician, and the gods thought he was a bit of a coward, lacking the courage to die for his love, as Alcestis did, but trying to find a way of getting into the underworld alive. They punished him further for that, giving him death at the hands of women.

In contrast, the man whom the gods honoured above all was Achilles, the son e
of Thetis. They sent him to the Islands of the Blessed. His mother had warned him that if he killed Hector he would himself be killed, but if he didn't, he would return home and live to a ripe old age. Nevertheless out of loyalty to his lover Patroclus he 180
chose without hesitation to die—not to save him, but to avenge him; for Patroclus had already been killed. The gods were full of admiration, and gave him the highest possible honour, because he valued his lover so highly.

Incidentally, Aeschylus' view, that it was Achilles who was in love with Patroclus, is nonsense. Quite apart from the fact that he was more beautiful than Patroclus (and than all the other Greek heroes, come to that) and had not yet grown a beard, he was also, according to Homer, much younger. And he must have been younger, because it is an undoubted fact that the gods, though they always value courage which comes from love, are most impressed and pleased, and grant the b
greatest rewards, when the younger man is loyal to his lover, than when the lover is loyal to him. That's because the lover is a more divine creature than the younger man, since he is divinely inspired. And that's why they honoured Achilles more than Alcestis, and sent him to the Islands of the Blessed.

There you are then. I claim that Eros is the oldest of the gods, the most

deserving of our respect, and the most useful, for those men, past and present, who want to attain excellence and happiness.

c That was the gist of Phaedrus' speech. After him, several other people spoke, but Aristodemus couldn't really remember what they said. So he left them out and recounted Pausanias' speech.

PAUSANIAS

Phaedrus, I don't think we've been very accurate in defining our subject for discussion. We've simply said that we must make a speech in praise of Eros. That would be fine, if there were just one Eros. In fact, however, there isn't. And since d there isn't, we would do better to define first which Eros we are to praise. I am going to try to put things straight—first defining which Eros we are supposed to be praising, and then trying to praise the god as he deserves.

We are all well aware, I take it, that without Eros there is no Aphrodite. If there were only one Aphrodite, there would be one Eros. However, since there are in fact two Aphrodites, it follows that Eros likewise must be two. There's no doubt about there being two Aphrodites; the older has no mother, and is the daughter of Heaven. We call her Heavenly Aphrodite. The younger is the daughter of Zeus and e Dione, and we call her Common Aphrodite. It follows that the Eros who assists this Aphrodite should also, properly speaking, be called Common Eros, and the other Heavenly Eros. We certainly ought to praise all the gods, but we should also attempt to define what is the proper province of each.

It is in general true of any activity that, simply in itself, it is neither good nor 181 bad. Take what we're doing now, for example—that is to say drinking, or singing, or talking. None of these is good or bad in itself, but each becomes so, depending on the way it is done. Well and rightly done, it is good; wrongly done, it is bad. And it's just the same with loving, and Eros. It's not all good, and doesn't all deserve praise. The Eros we should praise is the one which encourages people to love in the right way.

The Eros associated with Common Aphrodite is, in all senses of the word, b common, and quite haphazard in his operation. This is the love of the man in the

street. For a start, he is as likely to fall in love with women as with boys. Secondly, he falls in love with their bodies rather than their minds. Thirdly, he picks the most unintelligent people he can find, since all he's interested in is the sexual act. He doesn't care whether it's done in the right way or not. That is why the effect of this Eros is haphazard—sometimes good, sometimes the reverse. This love derives its existence from the much younger Aphrodite, the one composed equally of the c female and male elements.

The other Eros springs from Heavenly Aphrodite, and in the first place is composed solely of the male element, with none of the female (so it is the love of boys we are talking about), and in the second place is older, and hence free from lust. In consequence, those inspired by this love turn to the male, attracted by what is naturally stronger and of superior intelligence. And even among those who love d boys you can tell the ones whose love is purely heavenly. They only fall in love with boys old enough to think for themselves—in other words, with boys who are nearly grown up.

Those who start a love affair with boys of that age are prepared, I think, to be friends, and live together, for life. The others are deceivers, who take advantage of youthful folly, and then quite cheerfully abandon their victims in search of others. There ought really to be a law against loving young boys, to stop so much energy e being expended on an uncertain end. After all, no one knows how good or bad, in mind and body, young boys will eventually turn out. Good men voluntarily observe this rule, but the common lovers I am talking about should be compelled to do the same, just as we stop them, so far as we can, falling in love with free women. They 182 are actually the people who have brought the thing into disrepute, with the result that some people even go so far as to say that it is wrong to satisfy your lover. It is the common lover they have in mind when they say this, regarding his demands as premature and unfair to the boy. Surely nothing done with restraint and decency could reasonably incur criticism.

What is more, while sexual conventions in other states are clear-cut and easy to understand, here and in Sparta, by contrast, they are complex. In Elis, for b example, or Boeotia, and places where they are not sophisticated in their use of language, it is laid down, quite straightforwardly, that it is right to satisfy your lover. No one, old or young, would say it was wrong, and the reason, I take it, is that they don't want to have all the trouble of trying to persuade them verbally,

when they're such poor speakers. On the other hand, in Ionia and many other places under Persian rule, it is regarded as wrong. That is because the Persians' system of
c government (dictatorships) makes them distrust it, just as they distrust philosophy and communal exercise. It doesn't suit the rulers that their subjects should think noble thoughts, nor that they should form the strong friendships or attachments which these activities and in particular love tend to produce. Dictators here in Athens learnt the same lesson, by experience. The relationship between Harmodius and his lover, Aristogeiton, was strong enough to put an end to the dictators' rule.

d In short, the convention that satisfying your lover is wrong is a result of the moral weakness of those who observe the convention—the rulers' desire for power, and their subjects' cowardice. The belief that it is always right can be attributed to mental laziness. Our customs are much better but, as I said, not easy to understand. Think about it—let's take the lover first. Open love is regarded better than secret love, and so is love of the noblest and best people, even if they are not the best-looking. In fact, there is remarkable encouragement of the lover from all sides. He is not regarded as doing anything wrong; it is a good thing if he gets what he wants,
e and a shame if he doesn't. And when it comes to trying to get what he wants, we give the lover permission to do the most extraordinary things, and be applauded for them—things which, if he did them with any other aim or intention, would cover
183 him in reproach. Think of the way lovers behave towards the boys they love—think of the begging and entreating involved in their demands, the oaths they swear, the nights they spend sleeping outside the boys' front doors, the slavery they are prepared to endure (which no slave would put up with). If they behaved like this for money, or position, or influence of any kind, they would be told to stop by friends
b and enemies alike. Their enemies would call their behaviour dependent and servile, while their friends would censure them sharply, and even be embarrassed for them. And yet a lover can do all these things, and be approved of. Custom attaches no blame to his actions, since he is reckoned to be acting in a wholly honourable way. The strangest thing of all is that, in most people's opinion, the lover has a unique dispensation from the gods to swear an oath and then break it. Lovers' vows, apparently, are not binding.

c So far, then, gods and men alike give all kinds of licence to the lover, and an observer of Athenian life might conclude that it was an excellent thing, in this city, both to be a lover and to be friendly to lovers. But when we come to the boy, the

position is quite different. Fathers give their sons escorts, when men fall in love with them, and don't allow them to talk to their lovers—and those are the escort's instructions as well. The boy's peers and friends jeer at him if they see anything of the kind going on, and when their elders see them jeering, they don't stop them, or tell them off, as they should if the jeers were unjustified. Looking at this side of d
things, you would come to the opposite conclusion—that this kind of thing is here regarded as highly reprehensible.

The true position, I think, is this. Going back to my original statement, there isn't one single form of love. So love is neither right nor wrong in itself. Done rightly, it is right; done wrongly, it is wrong. It is wrong if you satisfy the wrong person, for the wrong reasons, and right if you satisfy the right person, for the right reasons. The wrong person is the common lover I was talking about—the one who loves the body rather than the mind. His love is not lasting, since *what* e
he loves is not lasting either. As soon as the youthful bloom of the body (which is what he loves) starts to fade, he "spreads his wings and is off", as they say, making a mockery of all his speeches and promises. On the other hand, the man who loves a boy for his good character will stick to him for life, since he has attached himself to what is lasting.

Our customs are intended to test these lovers well and truly, and get the boys 184
to satisfy the good ones, and avoid the bad. That's why we encourage lovers to chase after boys, but tell the boys not to be caught. In this way we set up a trial and a test, to see which category the lover comes in, and which category the boy he loves comes in. This explains a number of things—for instance, why it's thought wrong for a boy to let himself be caught too quickly. It is felt that some time should elapse, since time is a good test of most things. Also why it is wrong to be caught by means of money or political influence—whether it's a case of the boy being threatened, and yielding rather than holding out, or a case of being offered b
some financial or political inducement, and not turning it down. No affair of this kind is likely to be stable or secure, quite apart from the fact that it is no basis for true friendship.

There is just one way our customs leave it open for a boy to satisfy his lover, and not be blamed for it. It is permissible, as I have said, for a lover to enter upon any kind of voluntary slavery he may choose, and be the slave of the boy he loves. This c
is not regarded as self-seeking, or in any way demeaning. Similarly there is one other

kind of voluntary slavery which is not regarded as demeaning. This is the slavery of the boy, in his desire for improvement. It can happen that a boy chooses to serve a man, because he thinks that by association with him he will improve in wisdom in some way, or in some other form of goodness. This kind of voluntary slavery, like the other, is widely held among us not to be wrong, and not to be self-seeking.

d So it can only be regarded as right for a boy to satisfy his lover if both these conditions are satisfied—both the lover's behaviour, and the boy's desire for wisdom and goodness. Then the lover and the boy have the same aim, and each has the approval of convention—the lover because he is justified in performing any service he chooses for a boy who satisfies him, the boy because he is justified in submitting, in any way he will, to the man who can make him wise and good. So if c the lover has something to offer in the way of sound judgment and moral goodness, and if the boy is eager to accept this contribution to his education and growing wisdom, then, and only then, this favourable combination makes it right for a boy to satisfy his lover. In no other situation is it right.

Nor, in this situation, is there any disgrace in making a mistake, whereas in all 185 other situations it is equally a disgrace to be mistaken or not. For example, suppose a boy satisfies his lover for money, taking him to be rich. If he gets it wrong, and doesn't get any money, because the lover turns out to be poor, it is still regarded as immoral, because the boy who does this seems to be revealing his true character, and declaring that he would do anything for anyone in return for money. And that is not a good way to behave. Equally, a boy may satisfy a man because he thinks he is a good man, and that he himself will become better through his friendship. b If he gets it wrong, and his lover turns out to be a bad man, of little moral worth, still there is something creditable about his mistake. He too seems to have revealed his true character—namely, that he is eager to do anything for anyone in return for goodness and self-improvement. And this is the finest of all qualities.

So it is absolutely correct for boys to satisfy their lovers, if it is done in pursuit of goodness. This is the love which comes from the heavenly goddess; it is itself heavenly, and of great value to state and individual alike, since it compels c both lover and boy to devote a lot of attention to their own moral improvement. All other sorts of love derive from the other goddess, the common one.

Well, Phaedrus, that's the best I can offer, without preparation, on the subject of Eros.

Pausanias paused (sorry about the pun—sophistic influence). After that it was Aristophanes' turn to speak. But he had just got hiccups. I don't know if it was from eating too much, or for some other reason; anyway he was unable to make his speech. All he could say, since Eryximachus, the doctor, happened to be sitting d just below him, was this: "Eryximachus, you're just the man. Either get rid of my hiccups, or speak instead of me until they stop."

"I'll do both. I'll take your turn to speak, and when you get rid of your hiccups, you can take mine. While I'm speaking, try holding your breath for a long time, to see if they stop. Failing that, gargle with some water. And if they are very severe, tickle your nose and make yourself sneeze. Do that once or twice, and they'll stop, e however severe."

"Will you please speak first, then?" said Aristophanes. "And I'll do as you suggest."

ERYXIMACHUS

Pausanias made an impressive start to his speech, but I do not think he brought it to a very satisfactory conclusion. So I think it is important that I should try to complete 186 his account. His analysis of the twofold nature of Eros seems to me to be a valuable distinction. But I cannot accept his implication that Eros is found only in human hearts, and is aroused only by human beauty. I am a doctor by profession, and it has been my observation, I would say, throughout my professional career, that Eros is aroused by many other things as well, and that he is found also in nature—in the physical life of all animals, in plants that grow in the ground, and in virtually all living organisms. My conclusion is that he is great and awe-inspiring, this god, and b that his influence is unbounded, both in the human realm and in the divine.

I will begin by talking about my medical experience, to show my respect for my profession. The nature of the human body shows this twofold Eros, since it is generally agreed that health and sickness in the body are separate and unalike, and that unlike is attracted to unlike, and desires it. So there is one force of attraction for the healthy, and another for the sick. Pausanias was talking just now about it being right to satisfy men, if they are good men, but wrong if all they are interested in is physical pleasure. It is just the same with the body. It is right to satisfy the good c

and healthy elements in the body, and one should do so. We call this "medicine". Conversely it is wrong to satisfy the bad, unhealthy elements, and anyone who is going to be a skilled doctor should deny these elements.

Medical knowledge is thus essentially knowledge of physical impulses or
d desires for ingestion or evacuation. In this, the man who can distinguish healthy desires from unhealthy is the best doctor. Moreover he needs the ability to change people's desires, so that they lose one and gain another. There are people who lack desires which they should have. If the doctor can produce these desires, and remove the existing ones, then he is a good doctor. He must, in fact, be able to reconcile and harmonise the most disparate elements in the body. By "the most disparate" I mean
e those most opposed to one another—cold and hot, bitter and sweet, dry and wet, and so forth. It was by knowing how to produce mutual desire and harmony among these that our forerunner Asclepius, as the poets say (and I believe) established this art of ours.

187 Medicine, then, as I say, is completely governed by this god. Likewise physical training, and farming. Music too is no exception, as must be clear to anyone who gives the matter a moment's thought. Perhaps that is what Heraclitus means, though he does not actually express it very clearly, when he says that "the One" is "in conflict and harmony with itself", "like the stringing of a bow or lyre". Clearly there is a contradiction in saying that a harmony is in conflict, or is composed of conflicting elements. Perhaps what he meant was that, starting from initially
b discordant high and low notes, the harmony is only created when these are brought into agreement by the skill of the musician. Clearly there could be no harmony between high and low, if they were still in conflict. For harmony is a consonance, and consonance is a kind of agreement. Thus it is impossible that there should be a harmony of conflicting elements, in which those elements still conflict, nor can one harmonise what is different, and incapable of agreement. Or take rhythm as another example; it arises out of the conflict of quick and slow, but only when they cease
c to conflict. Here it is the art of music which imposes harmony on all the elements, by producing mutual attraction and agreement between them, whereas in the body it is the art of medicine. So music, again, is knowledge of Eros applied to harmony and rhythm.

In the actual formation of harmony and rhythm it is a simple matter to detect the hand of Eros, which at this stage is not the twofold Eros. It is altogether more

complicated when we come to apply rhythm and harmony to human activity, either to the making of music, which we call composing, or to the correct use of melody d
and tempo in what we call education. This really does demand a high degree of skill. And the same argument again holds good, that one should satisfy the most well-ordered people, in the interests of those as yet less well-ordered; one should pay due regard to their desires, which are in fact the good, heavenly Eros, companion of the heavenly muse, Ourania. Common Eros, by contrast, goes with the common muse, Polymnia. The greatest caution is called for in its employment, if one is to e
gain enjoyment from it without encouraging pure self-indulgence. Similarly, in my profession, there is a great art in the correct treatment of people's desire for rich food, so that they can enjoy it without ill effects.

Thus in music and medicine, and in all other spheres of activity, human and divine, we must keep a careful eye, so far as is practicable, on both forms of Eros. 188
For both are present. The seasons of the year likewise fully illustrate their joint operation. When all the things I was talking about just now (such as hot and cold, wet and dry) hit upon the right Eros in their relation to one another, and consequently form the right sort of mixture and harmony, then they bring what is seasonable and healthy, to men and to the rest of the world of animals and plants; and all is as it should be. But when the other Eros, in violence and excess, takes over in the natural seasons of the year, it does all sorts of damage, and upsets the natural order. When that happens the result, generally, is plague and a variety of diseases—for animals b
and plants alike. Frost, hail and mildew are the result of this kind of competition and disorder involving Eros. Knowledge of Eros in connection with the movements of the stars and the seasons of the year is called astronomy.

Then again, all sacrifices, and everything which comes under the direction of the prophetic arts (that is to say, the whole relationship of gods and men to one c
another) have as their sole concern the observance and correct treatment of Eros. If, in their behaviour towards their parents, the living and the dead, or the gods, people stop satisfying the good, well-ordered Eros, if they stop honouring him and consulting him in every enterprise, and start to follow the other Eros, then the result is all kinds of wickedness. So the prophetic arts have to keep an eye on, and treat, the two forms of Eros. Their knowledge of Eros in human affairs, the Eros who is d
conducive to piety and correct observance, makes them the architects of friendship between gods and men.

So great and widespread—in fact, universal—is the power possessed, in general by all Eros, but in particular by the Eros which, in the moral sphere, acts with good sense and justice both among us and among the gods. And not only does it possess absolute power; it also brings us complete happiness, enabling us to be companions and friends both of each other and of our superiors, the gods.

c Well, I too may have left a lot out in my praise of Eros, but I have not done so deliberately. And if I have left anything out, it is up to you, Aristophanes, to fill the gap. Or if you intend to praise the god in some other way, go ahead and do that, now that you have got rid of your hiccups.

189 ARISTOPHANES Yes, they've stopped, but not without resort to the sneezing treatment. I wondered if it was the "well-ordered" part of my body which demanded all the noise and tickling involved in sneezing. Certainly the hiccups stopped the moment I tried sneezing.

ERYXIMACHUS Careful, my dear friend. You haven't started yet, and already
b you're playing the fool. You'll force me to act as censor for your speech, if you start fooling around as soon as you get a chance to speak in peace.

ARISTOPHANES (laughing) Fair enough, Eryximachus. Regard my remarks so far as unsaid. But don't be too censorious. I'm worried enough already about what I'm going to say—not that it may arouse laughter (after all, there would be some point in that, and it would be appropriate to my profession), but that it may be laughed out of court.

ERYXIMACHUS Aristophanes, you're trying to eat your cake and have it. Come
c on, concentrate. You'll have to justify what you say, but perhaps, if I see fit, I will acquit you.

ARISTOPHANES

Well, Eryximachus, I do intend to make a rather different kind of speech from the kind you and Pausanias made. It's my opinion that mankind is quite unaware of the

power of Eros. If they were aware of it, they would build vast temples and altars to him, and make great offerings to him. As it is, though it is of crucial importance that this observance should be paid to him, none of these things is done.

Of all the gods, Eros is the most friendly towards men. He is our helper, and cures those evils whose cure brings the greatest happiness to the human race. I'll d try to explain his power to you, and then you can go off and spread the word to others.

First of all you need to know about human nature and what has happened to it. Our original nature was not as it is now, but quite different. For one thing there were three sexes, rather than the two (male and female) we have now. The third sex was e a combination of these two. Its name has survived, though the phenomenon itself has disappeared. This single combination, comprising both male and female, was, in form and name alike, hermaphrodite. Now it survives only as a term of abuse.

Secondly, each human being formed a complete whole, spherical, with back and ribs forming a circle. They had four hands, four legs, and two faces, identical in every way, on a circular neck. They had a single head for the two faces, which 190 looked in opposite directions; four ears, two sets of genitals, and everything else as you'd expect from the description so far. They walked upright, as we do, in whichever direction they wanted. And when they started to run fast, they were just like people doing cartwheels. They stuck their legs straight out all round, and went bowling along, supported on their eight limbs, and rolling along at high speed.

The reason for having three sexes, and of this kind, was this: the male was originally the offspring of the sun, the female of the earth, and the one which was b half-and-half was the offspring of the moon, because the moon likewise is half-sun and half-earth. They were circular, both in themselves and in their motion, because of their similarity to their parents. They were remarkable for their strength and vigour, and their ambition led them to make an assault upon the gods. The story which Homer tells of the giants, Ephialtes and Otus, is told of them—that they tried c to make a way up to heaven, to attack the gods. Zeus and the other gods wondered what to do about them, and couldn't decide. They couldn't kill them, as they had the giants—striking them with thunderbolts and doing away with the whole race—because the worship and sacrifices they received from men would have been done away with as well. On the other hand, they couldn't go on allowing them to behave so outrageously.

In the end Zeus, after long and painful thought, came up with a suggestion. "I think I have an idea. Men could go on existing, but behave less disgracefully, d if we made them weaker. I'm going to cut each of them in two. This will have two advantages: it will make them weaker, and also more useful to us, because of the increase in their numbers. They will walk upright, on two legs. And if it's clear they still can't behave, and they refuse to lead a quiet life, I'll cut them in half again and they can go hopping along on one leg."

e That was his plan. So he started cutting them in two, like someone slicing vegetables for pickling, or slicing eggs with a wire. And each time he chopped one up, he told Apollo to turn the face and the half-neck round towards the cut side (so that the man could see where he'd been split, and be better behaved in future), and then to heal the rest of the wound. So Apollo twisted the faces round and gathered up the skin all round to what is now called the stomach, like a purse with strings. 191 He made a single outlet, and tied it all up securely in the middle of the stomach; this we now call the navel. He smoothed out most of the wrinkles, and formed the chest, using a tool such as cobblers use for smoothing out wrinkles in a hide stretched over a last. He left a few wrinkles, however, those around the stomach itself and the navel, as a reminder of what happened in those far-off days.

When man's natural form was split in two, each half went round looking for its other half. They put their arms round one another, and embraced each other, in b their desire to grow together again. They started dying of hunger, and also from lethargy, because they refused to do anything separately. And whenever one half died, and the other was left, the survivor began to look for another, and twined itself about it, either encountering half of a complete woman (i.e. what we now call a woman) or half a complete man. In this way they kept on dying.

Zeus felt sorry for them, and thought of a second plan. He moved their genitals to the front—up till then they had had them on the outside, and had reproduced, c not by copulation, but by discharge on to the ground, like grasshoppers. So, as I say, he moved their genitals to the front, and made them use them for reproduction by insemination, the male in the female. The idea was that if, in embracing, a man chanced upon a woman, they could produce children, and the race would increase. If man chanced upon man, they could get full satisfaction from one another's company, then separate, get on with their work, and resume the business of life.

That is why we have this innate love of one another. It brings us back to our d original state, trying to reunite us and restore us to our true human form. Each of us is a mere fragment of a man (like half a tally-stick); we've been split in two, like filleted plaice. We're all looking for our "other half". Men who are a fragment of the common sex (the one called hermaphrodite), are womanisers, and most adulterers are to be found in this category. Similarly, women of this type are nymphomaniacs e and adulteresses. On the other hand, women who are part of an original woman pay very little attention to men. Their interest is in women; lesbians are found in this class. And those who are part of a male pursue what is male. As boys, because they are slices of the male, they are fond of men, and enjoy going to bed with men and embracing them. These are the best of the boys and young men, since they are by 192 nature the most manly. Some people call them immoral—quite wrongly. It is not immorality, but boldness, courage and manliness, since they take pleasure in what is like themselves. This is proved by the fact that, when they grow up and take part in public life, it's only this kind who prove themselves men. When they come to manhood, they are lovers of boys, and don't naturally show any interest in marriage or producing children; they have to be forced into it by convention. They're quite b happy to live with one another, and not get married.

People like this are clearly inclined to have boyfriends or (as boys) inclined to have lovers, because they always welcome what is akin. When a lover of boys (or any sort of lover) meets the real thing (i.e. his other half), he is completely overwhelmed by friendship and affection and desire, more or less refusing to be c separated for any time at all. These are the people who spend their whole lives together, and yet they cannot find words for what they want from one another. No one imagines that it's simply sexual intercourse, or that sex is the reason why one gets such enormous pleasure out of the other's company. No, it's obvious that the soul of each has some other desire, which it cannot express. It can only give hints d and clues to its wishes.

Imagine that Hephaestus came and stood over them, with his smith's tools, as they lay in bed together. Suppose he asked them, "What is it you want from one another, mortals?" If they couldn't tell him, he might ask again, "Do you want to be together as much as possible, and not be separated, day or night? If that's what you want, I'm quite prepared to weld you together, and make you grow into one. You

e can be united, the two of you, and live your whole life together, as one. Even down in Hades, when you die, you can be a single dead person, rather than two. Decide whether that's what you want, and whether that would satisfy you." We can be sure that no one would refuse this offer. Quite clearly, it would be just what they wanted. They'd simply think they'd been offered exactly what they'd always been after, in sexual intercourse, trying to melt into their lovers, and so be united.

So that's the explanation; it's because our original nature was as I have
193 described, and because we were once complete. And the name of this desire and pursuit of completeness is Eros, or love. Formerly, as I say, we were undivided, but now we've been split up by god for our misdeeds—like the Arcadians by the Spartans. And the danger is that, if we don't treat the gods with respect, we may be divided again, and go round looking like figures in a bas-relief, sliced in half down the line of our noses. We'd be like torn-off counterfoils. That's why we should all encourage the utmost piety towards the gods. We're trying to avoid this fate, and
b achieve the other. So we take Eros as our guide and leader. Let no one oppose this aim—and incurring divine displeasure *is* opposing this aim—since if we are friends with god, and make our peace with him, we shall find and meet the boys who are part of ourselves, which few people these days succeed in doing.

I hope Eryximachus won't misunderstand me, and make fun of my speech, and say it's about Pausanias and Agathon. Perhaps they do come in this class, and
c are both males by nature. All I'm saying is that in general (and this applies to men and women) this is where happiness for the human race lies—in the successful pursuit of love, in finding the love who is part of our original self, and in returning to our former state. This is the ideal, but in an imperfect world we must settle for the nearest to this we can get, and this is finding a boyfriend who is mentally congenial. And if we want to praise the god who brings this about, then we should
d praise Eros, who in this predicament is our great benefactor, attracting us to what is part of ourselves, and gives us great hope for the future that he will reward respect for the gods by returning us to our original condition, healing us, and making us blessed and perfectly happy.

There you are then, Eryximachus. There is my speech about Eros. A bit different from yours, I'm afraid. So please, again, don't laugh at it, and let's hear
e what all the others have to say—or rather, both the others, since only Agathon and Socrates are left.

ERYXIMACHUS All right, I won't laugh. In any case, I thought it was a most enjoyable speech. In fact, if I did not know Socrates and Agathon to be experts on love, I would be very worried that they might have nothing to say, so abundant and varied have been the speeches so far. But knowing them as I do, I have no such anxiety.

SOCRATES It's fine for you, Eryximachus. You've already made an excellent 194
speech. If you were in my shoes—or rather, perhaps, the shoes I will be in when Agathon has made a good speech as well—then you might well be alarmed, and be in precisely the state that I am in now.

AGATHON Ah! Trying a little black magic, are you, Socrates? Are you hoping it'll make me nervous if I think the audience is expecting a great speech from me?

SOCRATES Agathon, I've seen your nerve and courage in going up on the platform b
with the actors, to present your plays, before the eyes of that vast audience. You were quite unperturbed by that, so it'd be pretty stupid of me to imagine that you'd be nervous in front of the few people here.

AGATHON I may be stage-struck, Socrates, but I'm still aware that, to anyone with any sense, a small critical audience is far more daunting than a large uncritical one.

SOCRATES It would be quite wrong for me, of all people, to suggest that you are c
lacking in taste or judgement. I'm well aware that in all your contacts with those you consider discriminating, you value their opinion more highly than that of the public. But don't put us in that category—after all, we were there, we were part of "the public". Anyway, let's pursue this: if you came across truly discriminating people (not us), you would perhaps be daunted by them, if you thought you were producing something second-rate. Is that right?

AGATHON It is.

SOCRATES Whereas offering the public something second-rate would not worry you, would it?

d PHAEDRUS Agathon, if you answer Socrates, he won't give a thought to the rest of us, so long as he has someone to talk to, particularly someone good-looking. For myself, I love hearing Socrates talk, but it's my job to supervise the progress of the speeches in praise of Eros, and get a speech out of each of you. When you've both paid your tribute to the god, then the two of you can get on with your discussion.

e AGATHON Quite right, Phaedrus. There's no reason why I shouldn't make my speech. I shall have plenty of other opportunities to talk to Socrates.

AGATHON

I want first to talk about *how* I should talk, and then talk. All the speakers so far have given me the impression that they were not so much praising the god as congratulating mankind on the good things the god provides. No one has told us 195 what the giver of these benefits is really like, in himself. And yet, in any speech of praise on any subject, the only correct procedure is to work systematically through the subject under discussion, saying what its nature is, and what benefits it gives. That is how we too should by rights be praising Eros, describing first his nature, then his gifts.

I claim, then, that though all the gods are blessed, Eros, if I may say this without offending the other gods, is the most blessed, since he is the most beautiful b and the best. The most beautiful? Well, for a start, Phaedrus, he is the youngest of the gods. He proves this himself by running away at top speed from old age. Yet old age is swift enough, and swifter than most of us would like. It is Eros' nature to hate old age, and steer well clear of it. He lives and exists always with the young. "Birds of a feather", and all that. So, though there was much in Phaedrus' speech with which I agreed, I didn't agree with his claim that Eros was older than Cronus or Iapetus. I would say he's the youngest of the gods—eternally young, in fact. The c earliest troubles among the gods, which Hesiod and Parmenides write about, were, if those writers are correct, the work of Necessity, not of Eros. If Eros had been there, there would have been none of this cutting, or tying, each other up, or any of the other acts of violence. There would have been friendship and peace, as there has been since Eros became king of the gods.

So, he is young. And not only young, but delicate. You need a poet like Homer to show how delicate. Homer describes Ate as a god and as delicate (or at any d rate, with delicate feet): 'delicate are her feet; she walks not upon the ground, but goes upon the heads of men.' Presumably he's giving an example here to show how delicate—she goes not on what is hard, but on what is soft. We too can use a similar argument to show how delicate Eros is. He does not walk upon the ground, e nor yet on men's heads (which aren't that soft anyway); he lives and moves among the softest of all things, making his home in the hearts and minds of gods and men. And not in all hearts equally. He avoids any hard hearts he comes across, and settles among the tender-hearted. He must therefore be extremely delicate, since he only ever touches (either with his feet or in any other way) the softest of the soft.

Very young, then, and very delicate. Another thing about him is that he's very 196 supple. He can't be rigid and unyielding, because he wouldn't be able to insinuate himself anywhere he likes, entering and leaving men's hearts undetected. Eros' outstanding beauty is universally agreed, and this again suggests that he is well-proportioned and supple. Ugliness and Eros are ever at odds with one another. Finally, the beauty of his skin is attested by his love of flowers. He will not settle in a man's body, or heart, or anywhere else, if it is past the first flower and bloom of b youth. But he does settle down, and remain, in any flowery and fragrant place.

So much for the god's beauty, though I've left out more than I've said. Now I must say something about his goodness. The main thing about Eros is that no one, god or man, wrongs him or is wronged by him. Nothing is done to him, when it is done, by force. Force cannot touch Eros. When he acts, he acts without force, since c everyone serves Eros quite willingly, and it's agreed by "our masters, the laws" that where there is mutual consent and agreement, there is justice. Moreover, he is a paragon of virtue as well as justice. After all, virtue is agreed to be control of pleasures and desires, and no pleasure is stronger than love. But if they are weaker than love, then he has control over them, and if he has control over pleasures and desires, he must be highly virtuous.

And what about courage? "Ares himself cannot hold his ground" against Eros. d Ares does not take Eros prisoner; it is Eros—the love of Aphrodite, so the story goes—who takes Ares prisoner, and the captor is stronger than the captive. He who overcomes the bravest is himself the bravest of all.

So much for the god's justice, virtue and courage. Now for his wisdom. I must

try as hard as I can not to leave anything out, and so I too, in my turn, will start with a tribute to my own profession, following Eryximachus' example. Eros is an
e accomplished poet, so accomplished that he can turn others into poets. Everyone turns to poetry, "however philistine he may have been before", when moved by Eros. We should take this as an indication that, in general, Eros is master of all forms of literary or artistic creation. After all, no one can impart, or teach, a skill which he does not himself possess or know. And who will deny that the creation of
197 all living things is the work of Eros' wisdom, which makes all living things come into being and grow?

It's the same with any skilled activity. It is common knowledge that those who have this god for their teacher win fame and reputation; those he passes by remain in obscurity. For example, Apollo's discoveries (archery, medicine and prophecy)
b were all guided by desire and love, so he too can be called a disciple of Eros. Likewise with the Muses and the arts, Hephaestus and metalworking, Athene and weaving, and Zeus and "the governance of gods and men". And if we ask why the quarrels of the gods were settled as soon as Eros appeared, without doubt the reason was love of beauty (there being no love of ugliness). In earlier times, as I said originally, there were many violent quarrels among the gods—or so we are told—because they were in the grip of Necessity. But since Eros' birth, all manner of good has resulted, for gods and men, from the love of beauty.

c Such, Phaedrus, is my view of Eros. He stands out as beautiful and excellent in himself; and secondly, he is the origin of similar qualities in others. I am tempted to speak in verse, and say he brings

> Sweet peace to men, and calm o'er all the deep,
> Rest to the winds, to those who sorrow, sleep.

d He gives us the feeling, not of longing, but of belonging, since he is the moving spirit behind all those occasions when we meet and gather together. Festivals, dances, sacrifices—in these he is the moving spirit. Implanter of gentleness, supplanter of fierceness; generous with his kindness, ungenerous with unkindness; gracious, gentle; an example to the wise, a delight to the gods; craved by those without him, saved by those who have him; of luxury, delicacy, elegance, charm, yearning and desire he is the father; heedful of the good, heedless of the bad; in hardship and
e in fear, in need and in argument, he is the best possible helmsman, comrade, ally,

and saviour; the glory of gods and men; the best and finest guide, whom every man should follow, singing glorious praises to him, and sharing in the song which he sings to enchant the minds of gods and men.

That is my speech, Phaedrus, in part fun, in part (as far as I could make it) fairly serious. Let it be an offering to the god.

When Agathon finished speaking, we all burst into applause. We thought the young 198
man had done full justice both to himself and to the god.

SOCRATES (to Eryximachus) Well, son of Acumenus, do you still think my earlier fear unfounded? Wasn't I right when I predicted Agathon would make a brilliant speech, and there would be nothing left for me to say?

ERYXIMACHUS Your prediction was half-true. Agathon did make a good speech. But I don't think you will find nothing to say.

SOCRATES My dear fellow, what is there left for me or anyone else to say, after b
such a fine and varied speech? Maybe it wasn't all equally brilliant, but that bit at the end was enough to silence anyone with the beauty of its language and phraseology. When I realised I wasn't going to be able to make anything like such a good speech, I nearly ran away and disappeared, in embarrassment, only there was nowhere c
to go. The speech reminded me of Gorgias, and put me in exactly the position described by Homer. I was afraid, at the end of his speech there, that Agathon was going to brandish the head of Gorgias, the great speaker, at my speech, turning me to stone and silencing me. I realised then how fatuous it was to have agreed to take my turn with you in praising Eros, and to have claimed to be an expert on love. It d
turns out now that I know nothing at all about making speeches of praise. I was naive enough to suppose that one should speak the truth about whatever it was that was being praised, and that from this raw material one should select the most telling points, and arrange them as pleasingly as possible. I was pretty confident I would make a good speech, because I thought I knew about speeches of praise. However, it now seems that praising things well isn't like that; it seems to be a question of hyperbole and rhetoric, regardless of truth or falsehood. And if it's false, that's e
immaterial. So our original agreement, as it now seems, was that each of us should pretend to praise Eros, rather than really praise him.

That, I imagine, is why you credit Eros with all the good points you have dug out in his favour. You say his nature is this, and the blessings he produces are these; your object is to make him appear as noble and fine as possible (in the eyes
199 of the ignorant, presumably, since those who know about Eros clearly aren't going to believe you). Certainly your praise of him looks very fine and impressive, but I didn't realise this was what was called for; if I had known I wouldn't have agreed to take my turn in praising him. "My tongue promised, not my heart." Anyway, it can't be helped, but I don't propose to go on praising him like that—I wouldn't know how to. What I am prepared to do, if you like, is tell the truth, in my own way,
b and not in competition with your speeches. I don't want to make a complete fool of myself. What do you think, Phaedrus? Do you want a speech of that sort? Do you want to hear the truth told about Eros? And may I use whatever language and forms of speech come naturally?

Phaedrus and the others told him to make his speech, in what ever way he thought best.

SOCRATES One other point before I start, Phaedrus. Will you let me ask Agathon a few brief questions? I'd like to get his agreement before I begin.

c PHAEDRUS Yes, I'll let you. Ask away.

So Socrates began his speech, something like this.

SOCRATES

Well, my dear Agathon, I liked the beginning of your speech. You said the first thing to do was to reveal the nature of Eros; after that his achievements. I think that was an excellent starting point. And since you've explained everything else about the nature of Eros so impressively and so well, can you tell me one more thing?
d Is Eros' nature such that he is love produced by something, or by nothing? I don't mean, is he the son of a father or a mother—it would be an absurd question, to ask whether Eros is son of a father or mother. But suppose I asked you, about this

thing "father", whether a father is father of something or not? If you wanted to give an accurate answer, you would say, presumably, that a father is father of a son or a daughter, wouldn't you?

AGATHON Yes, I would.

SOCRATES And the same with a mother?

AGATHON Yes, the same.

SOCRATES Let's take a few more questions, so you can be quite clear what c
I mean. Suppose I ask, "What about a brother, simply as a brother? Is he someone's brother, or not?"

AGATHON Yes, he is.

SOCRATES His brother's or sister's, I take it?

AGATHON Yes.

SOCRATES Try, then, to answer my question about Eros. Is Eros love of nothing, or of something?

AGATHON Of something, certainly.

SOCRATES Good. Hold on to that answer. Keep it in mind, and make a mental 200
note what it is that Eros is love of. But first tell me this, this thing which Eros is love of, does he desire it, or not?

AGATHON Certainly.

SOCRATES And does he possess that which he desires and loves, or not?

AGATHON Probably not.

SOCRATES I'm not interested in probability, but in certainty. Consider this proposition: anything which desires something desires what it does not have, and it
b only desires when it is lacking something. This proposition, Agathon, seems to me to be absolutely certain. How does it strike you?

AGATHON Yes, it seems certain to me too.

SOCRATES Quite right. So would a big man want to be big, or a strong man want to be strong?

AGATHON No, that's impossible, given what we have agreed so far.

SOCRATES Because if he possesses these qualities, he cannot also lack them.

AGATHON True.

SOCRATES So if a strong man wanted to be strong, or a fast runner to be fast, or a healthy man to be healthy—but perhaps I'd better explain what I'm on
c about. I'm a bit worried that you may think that people like this, people having these qualities, can also want the qualities which they possess. So I'm trying to remove this misapprehension. If you think about it, Agathon, people cannot avoid possession of whichever of these qualities they do possess, whether they like it or not. So obviously there's no point in desiring to do so. When anyone says, "I'm in good health, and I also desire to be in good health", or "I am rich and also desire to be rich", i.e. "I desire those things which I already have", then we should answer him: "What you want is to go on possessing, in the future, the
d wealth, health, or strength you possess now, since you have them now, like it or not. So when you say you desire what you've already got, are you sure you don't just mean you want to continue to possess in the future what you possess now?" Would he deny this?

AGATHON No, he would agree.

SOCRATES But isn't this a question of desiring what he doesn't already have in his possession—i.e. the desire that what he does have should be safely and permanently available to him in the future?

AGATHON Yes, it is. e

SOCRATES So in this, or any other, situation, the man who desires something desires what is not available to him, and what he doesn't already have in his possession. And what he neither has nor himself is—that which he lacks—this is what he wants and desires.

AGATHON Absolutely.

SOCRATES Right then, let's agree on the argument so far. Eros has an existence of his own; he is in the first place love of something, and secondly, he is love of that which he is without.

AGATHON Yes. 201

SOCRATES Keeping that in mind, just recall what you said were the objects of Eros, in your speech. I'll remind you, if you like. I think what you said amounted to this: trouble among the gods was ended by their love of beauty, since there could be no love of what is ugly. Isn't that roughly what you said?

AGATHON Yes, it is.

SOCRATES And a very reasonable statement too, my friend. And this being so, Eros must have an existence as love of beauty, and not love of ugliness, mustn't he?

AGATHON Yes.

SOCRATES But wasn't it agreed that he loves what he lacks, and does not b possess?

AGATHON Yes, it was.

SOCRATES So Eros lacks, and does not possess, beauty.

AGATHON That is the inevitable conclusion.

SOCRATES Well then, do you describe as beautiful that which lacks beauty and has never acquired beauty?

AGATHON No.

SOCRATES If that is so, do you still maintain that Eros is beautiful?

AGATHON I rather suspect, Socrates, that I didn't know what I was talking about.

c SOCRATES It sounded marvellous, for all that, Agathon. Just one other small point. Would you agree that what is good is also beautiful?

AGATHON Yes, I would.

SOCRATES So if Eros lacks beauty, and if what is good is beautiful, then Eros would lack what is good also.

AGATHON I can't argue with you, Socrates. Let's take it that it is as you say.

SOCRATES What you mean, Agathon, my very good friend, is that you can't argue with the truth. Any fool can argue with Socrates. Anyway, I'll let you off for
d now, because I want to pass on to you the account of Eros which I once heard given by a woman called Diotima, from Mantinea. She was an expert on this subject, as on many others. In the days before the plague she came to the help of the Athenians in their sacrifices, and managed to gain them a ten-years' reprieve from the disease. She also taught me about love.

I'll start from the position on which Agathon and I reached agreement, and I'll give her account, as best I can, in my own words. So first I must explain, as you rightly
e laid down, Agathon, what Eros is and what he is like; then I must describe what he does. I think it'll be easiest for me to explain things as she explained them when she was questioning me, since I gave her pretty much the same answers Agathon has just been giving me. I said Eros was a great god, and a lover of beauty. Diotima proved to me, using the same argument by which I have just proved it to Agathon, that, according to my own argument, Eros was neither beautiful nor good.

"What do you mean, Diotima," I said, "Is Eros then ugly or bad?"

"Careful what you say. Do you think what is not beautiful must necessarily be ugly?"

"Obviously." 202

"And that what is not wise is ignorant? Don't you realise there is an intermediate state, between wisdom and ignorance?"

"And what is that?"

"Think of someone who has a correct opinion, but can give no rational explanation of it. You wouldn't call this knowledge (how can something irrational be knowledge?), yet it isn't ignorance either, since an opinion which accords with reality cannot be ignorance. So correct opinion is the kind of thing we are looking for, between understanding and ignorance."

"That's true."

"So don't insist that what is not beautiful must necessarily be ugly, nor that b what is not good must be bad. The same thing is equally true of Eros; just because, as you yourself admit, he is not good or beautiful, you need not regard him as ugly and bad, but as something between these extremes."

"Yet he is universally agreed to be a great god."

"By those who don't know what they are talking about, do you mean? Or those who do?"

"I mean by absolutely everyone."

Diotima laughed. "How can Eros be agreed to be a great god by people who c don't even admit that he's a god at all?"

"What people?"

"Well, you, for one. And me, for another."

"What do you mean?"

"Quite simple. The gods are all happy and beautiful, aren't they? You wouldn't go so far as to claim that any of the gods is not happy and beautiful?"

"Good Lord, no."

"And you agree that 'happy' means 'possessing what is good and beautiful'?"

"Certainly."

"But you have already admitted that Eros lacks what is good and beautiful, d and that he desires them because he lacks them."

"Yes, I have."

"How can he be a god, then, if he is without beauty and goodness?"

"He can't, apparently."

"You see, even you don't regard Eros as a god."

"What can Eros be, then? A mortal?"

"Far from it."

"What, then?"

"As in the other examples, something between a mortal and an immortal."

"And what is that, Diotima?"

c "A great spirit, Socrates. Spirits are midway between what is divine and what is human."

"What power does such a spirit possess?"

"He acts as an interpreter and means of communication between gods and men. He takes requests and offerings to the gods, and brings back instructions and benefits in return. Occupying this middle position he plays a vital role in holding the world together. He is the medium of all prophecy and religion, whether it concerns sacrifice, forms of worship, incantations, or any kind of divination
203 or sorcery. There is no direct contact between god and man. All association and communication between them, waking or sleeping, takes place through Eros. This kind of knowledge is knowledge of the spirit; any other knowledge (occupational or artistic, for example) is purely utilitarian. Such spirits are many and varied, and Eros is one of them."

"Who are his parents?"

b "That is not quite so simple, but I'll tell you, all the same. When Aphrodite was born, the gods held a banquet, at which one of the guests was Resource, the son of Ingenuity. When they finished eating, Poverty came begging, as you would expect (there being plenty of food), and hung around the doorway. Resource was drunk (on nectar, since wine hadn't been invented), so he went into Zeus' garden, and was overcome by sleep. Poverty, seeing here the solution to her own lack of resources, decided to have a child by him. So she lay with him, and conceived
c Eros. That's why Eros is a follower and servant of Aphrodite, because he was conceived at her birthday party—and also because he is naturally attracted to what is beautiful, and Aphrodite is beautiful.

So Eros' attributes are what you would expect of a child of Resource and Poverty. For a start, he's always poor, and so far from being soft and beautiful (which

is most people's view of him), he is hard, unkempt, barefoot, homeless. He sleeps on d
the ground, without a bed, lying in doorways or in the open street. He has his mother's nature, and need is his constant companion. On the other hand, from his father he has inherited an eye for beauty and the good. He is brave, enterprising and determined—a marvellous huntsman, always intriguing. He is intellectual, resourceful, a lover of wisdom his whole life through, a subtle magician, sorcerer and thinker.

His nature is neither that of an immortal nor that of a mortal. In one and the e
same day he can be alive and flourishing (when things go well), then at death's door, later still reviving as his father's character asserts itself again. But his resources are always running out, so that Eros is never either totally destitute or affluent. Similarly he is midway between wisdom and folly, as I will show you. None of the gods searches for wisdom, or tries to become wise—they are wise already. Nor does 204
anyone else wise search for wisdom. On the other hand, the foolish do not search for wisdom or try to become wise either, since folly is precisely the failing which consists in not being fine and good, or intelligent—and yet being quite satisfied with the way one is. You cannot desire what you do not realise you lack."

"Who then are the lovers of wisdom, Diotima, if they are neither the wise nor the foolish?"

"That should by now be obvious, even to a child. They must be the intermediate b
class, among them Eros. We would classify wisdom as very beautiful, and Eros is love of what is beautiful, so it necessarily follows that Eros is a lover of wisdom (lovers of wisdom being the intermediate class between the wise and the foolish). The reason for this, too, is to be found in his parentage. His father is wise and resourceful, while his mother is foolish and resourceless.

"Such is the nature of this spirit, Socrates. Your views on Eros revealed a quite common mistake. You thought (or so I infer from your comments) that Eros was c
what was loved, rather than the lover. That is why you thought Eros was beautiful. After all, what we love really *is* beautiful and delicate, perfect and delightful, whereas the lover has the quite different character I have outlined."

"Fair enough, my foreign friend, I think you're right. But if that's what Eros is like, what use is he to men?"

"That's the next point I want to explain to you, Socrates. I've told you what d
Eros is like, and what his parentage is; he is also love of what is beautiful, as you say. Now let's imagine someone asking us, 'Why is Eros love of the beautiful,

Socrates and Diotima?' Let me put it more clearly: what is it that the lover of beauty desires?"

"To possess it."

"That prompts the further question, what good does it do someone to possess beauty?"

"I don't quite know how to give a quick answer to that question."

e "Well, try a different question, about goodness rather than beauty: Socrates, what does the lover of goodness want?"

"To possess it."

"What good will it do him to possess it?"

"That's easier. It will make him happy."

205 "Yes, because those who are happy are happy because they possess what is good. The enquiry seems to have reached a conclusion, and there is no need to ask the further question, 'If someone wants to be happy, why does he want to be happy?' "

"True."

"Do you think this wish and this desire are common to all mankind, and that everyone wants always to possess what is good? Or what do you think?"

"I think it is common to all men."

"In that case, Socrates, why do we not describe all men as lovers, if everyone b always loves the same thing? Why do we describe some people as lovers, but not others?"

"I don't know. I agree with you, it is surprising."

"Not really. We abstract a part of love, and call it by the name of the whole—love—and then for the other parts we use different names."

"What names? Give me an example."

"What about this? Take a concept like creation, or composition. Composition means putting things together, and covers a wide range of activities. Any activity c which brings anything at all into existence is an example of creation. Hence the exercise of any skill is composition, and those who practise it are composers."

"True."

"All the same, they aren't all called composers. They all have different names, and it's only one subdivision of the whole class (that which deals with music and rhythm) which is called by the general name. Only this kind of creation is called

composing, and its practitioners composers."

"True."

"Well, it's the same with love. In general, for anyone, any desire for goodness d and happiness is love—and it is a powerful and unpredictable force. But there are various ways of pursuing this desire—through money-making, through physical fitness, through philosophy—which do not entitle their devotees to call themselves lovers, or describe their activity as loving. Those who pursue one particular mode of loving, and make that their concern, have taken over the name of the whole (love, loving and lovers)."

"You may well be right."

"There is a theory that lovers are people in search of their other half. But e according to my theory, love is not love of a half, nor of a whole, unless it is good. After all, men are prepared to have their own feet and hands cut off, if they think there's something wrong with them. They're not particularly attached to what is their own, except in so far as they regard the good as their own property, and evil 206 as alien to them. And that's because the good is the only object of human love, as I think you will agree."

"Yes, I certainly do agree."

"Can we say, then, quite simply, that men love the good?"

"Yes."

"And presumably we should add that they want to possess the good?"

"Yes, we should."

"And not merely to possess it, but to possess it for ever."

"That also."

"In short, then, love is the desire for permanent possession of the good."

"Precisely."

"If this is always the object of our desire, what is the particular manner of b pursuit, and the particular sphere of activity, in which enthusiasm and effort qualify for the title 'love'? What is this activity? Do you know?"

"No, I don't. That's why I find your knowledge so impressive. In fact, I've kept coming to see you, because I want an answer to just that question."

"Very well, I'll tell you. The activity we're talking about is the use of what is beautiful for the purpose of reproduction, whether physical or mental."

"I'm no good at riddles. I don't understand what you mean."

e "I'll try to make myself clearer. Reproduction, Socrates, both physical and mental, is a universal human activity. At a certain age our nature desires to give birth. To do so, it cannot employ an ugly medium, but insists on what is beautiful. Sexual intercourse between man and woman is this reproduction. So there is the divine element, this germ of immortality, in mortal creatures—i.e. conception and begetting. These cannot take place in an uncongenial medium, and ugliness is
d uncongenial to everything divine, while beauty is congenial. Therefore procreation has Beauty as its midwife and its destiny, which is why the urge to reproduce becomes gentle and happy when it comes near beauty: then conception and begetting become possible. By contrast, when it comes near ugliness it becomes sullen and offended, it contracts, withdraws, and shrinks away and does not beget. It stifles the reproductive urge, and is frustrated. So in anyone who is keen (one might almost say bursting) to reproduce, beauty arouses violent emotion, because
e beauty can release its possessor from the agony of reproduction. Your opinion, Socrates, that love is desire for beauty, is mistaken."

"What is the correct view, then?"

"It is the desire to use beauty to beget and bear offspring."

"Perhaps."

"Certainly! And why to beget? Because begetting is, by human standards,
207 something eternal and undying. So if we were right in describing love as the desire always to possess the good, then the inevitable conclusion is that we desire immortality as well as goodness. On this argument, love must be desire for immortality as much as for beauty."

Those were her teachings, when she talked to me about love. And one day she asked me, "What do you think is the reason for this love and this desire? You know how strangely animals behave when they want to mate. Animals and birds, they're just the same. Their health suffers, and they get all worked up, first over
b sexual intercourse, and then over raising the young. For these ends they will fight, to the death, against far stronger opponents. They will go to any lengths, even starve themselves, to bring up their offspring. We can easily imagine human beings behaving like this from rational motives, but what can be the cause of such altruistic behaviour in animals? Do you know?"

c "No, I don't."

"Do you think you can become an expert on love without knowing?"

"Look, Diotima, I know I have a lot to learn. I've just admitted that. That's why I've come to you. So please tell me the cause of these phenomena, and anything else I should know about love."

"Well, if you believe that the natural object of love is what we have often agreed it to be, then the answer is not surprising, since the same reasoning still holds good. What is mortal tries, to the best of its ability, to be everlasting and immortal. d
It does this in the only way it can, by always leaving a successor to replace what decays. Think of what we call the life-span and identity of an individual creature. For example, a man is said to be the same individual from childhood until old age. The cells in his body are always changing, yet he is still called the same person, despite being perpetually reconstituted as parts of him decay—hair, flesh, bones, blood, his whole body, in fact. And not just his body, either. Precisely the same e
happens with mental attributes. Habits, dispositions, beliefs, opinions, desires, pleasures, pains and fears are all varying all the time for everyone. Some disappear, 208
others take their place. And when we come to knowledge, the situation is even odder. It is not just a question of one piece of knowledge disappearing and being replaced by another, so that we are never the same people, as far as knowledge goes: the same thing happens with each individual piece of knowledge. What we call studying presupposes that knowledge is transient. Forgetting is loss of knowledge, and studying preserves knowledge by creating memory afresh in us, to replace what is lost. Hence we have the illusion of continuing knowledge.

"All continuous mortal existence is of this kind. It is not the case that creatures remain always, in every detail, precisely the same—only the divine does that. It is rather that what is lost, and what decays, always leaves behind a fresh copy of itself. b
This, Socrates, is the mechanism by which mortal creatures can taste immortality—both physical immortality, and other sorts. (For immortals, of course, it's different.) So it's not surprising that everything naturally values its own offspring. They all feel this concern, and this love, because of their desire for immortality."

I found these ideas totally novel, and I said, "Well, Diotima, that's a very clever explanation. Is it really all true?" And she, in her best lecturer's manner, c
replied, "There can be no question of it. Take another human characteristic, ambition. It seems absurdly irrational until you remember my explanation. Think of the extraordinary behaviour of those who, prompted by Eros, are eager to become famous, and 'amass undying fame for the whole of time to come.' For this they will

expose themselves to danger even more than they will for their children. They will
d spend money, endure any hardship, even die for it. Think of Alcestis' willingness to die for Admetus, or Achilles' determination to follow Patroclus in death, or your Athenian king Codrus and his readiness to give up his life for his children's right to rule. Would they have done these things if they hadn't thought they were leaving behind them an undying memory which we still possess—of their courage? Of course not. The desire for undying nobility, and the good reputation which goes
e with it, is a universal human motive. The nobler people are, the more strongly they feel it. They desire immortality.

"Those whose creative urge is physical tend to turn to women, and pursue Eros by this route. The production of children gains them, as they imagine, immortality
209 and a name and happiness for themselves, for all time. In others the impulse is mental or spiritual—people who are creative mentally, much more than physically. They produce what you would expect the mind to conceive and produce. And what is that? Thought, and all other human excellence. All poets are creators of this kind, and so are those artists who are generally regarded as inventive. However, under the general heading 'thought', by far the finest and most important item is the art of political and domestic economy, what we call good judgement, and justice.

"Someone who, right from his youth, is mentally creative in these areas, when
b he is ready, and the time comes, feels a strong urge to give birth, or beget. So he goes around, like everyone else, searching, as I see it, for a medium of beauty in which he can create. He will never create in an ugly medium. So in his desire to create he is attracted to what is physically beautiful rather than ugly. But if he comes across a beautiful, noble, well-formed mind, then he finds the combination particularly attractive. He'll drop everything and embark on long conversations about goodness, with such a companion, trying to teach him about the nature and
c behaviour of the good man. Now that he's made contact with someone beautiful, and made friends with him, he can produce and bring to birth what he long ago conceived. Present or absent, he keeps it in mind, and joins with his friends in bringing his conception to maturity. In consequence such people have a far stronger bond between them than there is between the parents of children; and they form much firmer friendships, because they are jointly responsible for finer, and more lasting, offspring.

d "We would all choose children of this kind for ourselves, rather than human

children. We look with envy at Homer and Hesiod, and the other great poets, and the marvellous progeny they left behind, which have brought them undying fame and memory: or, if you like, at children of the kind which Lycurgus left in Sparta, the salvation of Sparta and practically all Greece. In your city, Solon is highly thought of, as the father of your laws, as are many other men in other states, both Greek e
and foreign. They have published to the world a variety of noble achievements, and created goodness of every kind. There are shrines to such people in honour of their offspring, but none to the producers of ordinary children.

"You, too, Socrates, could probably be initiated this far into knowledge of Eros. But all this, rightly pursued, is a mere preliminary to the full rites, and final 210
revelation, which might well be beyond you. Still, I'll tell you about it, so that if I fail, it won't be for want of trying. Try to follow if you can.

"The true follower of this subject must begin, as a young man, with the pursuit of physical beauty. In the first place, if his mentor advises him properly, he should be attracted, physically, to one individual; at this stage his offspring are beautiful discussions and conversations. Next he should realise that the physical beauty of b
one body is akin to that of any other body, and that if he's going to pursue beauty of appearance, it's the height of folly not to regard the beauty which is in all bodies as one and the same. This insight will convert him into a lover of all physical beauty, and he will become less obsessive in his pursuit of his one former passion, as he realises its unimportance.

"The next stage is to put a higher value on mental than on physical beauty. The right qualities of mind, even in the absence of any great physical beauty, will be enough to awaken his love and affection. He will generate the kind of discussions c
which are improving to the young. The aim is that, as the next step, he should be compelled to contemplate the beauty of customs and institutions, to see that all beauty of this sort is related, and consequently to regard physical beauty as trivial.

"From human institutions his teacher should direct him to knowledge, so that he may, in turn, see the beauty of different types of knowledge. Whereas before, in servile and contemptible fashion, he was dominated by the individual case, loving d
the beauty of a boy, or a man, or a single human activity, now he directs his eyes to what is beautiful in general, as he turns to gaze upon the limitless ocean of beauty. Now he produces many fine and inspiring thoughts and arguments, as he gives his undivided attention to philosophy. Here he gains in strength and stature until his

attention is caught by that one special knowledge—the knowledge of a beauty
e which I will now try to describe to you. So pay the closest possible attention.

"When a man has reached this point in his education in love, studying the different types of beauty in correct order, he will come to the final end and goal of this education. Then suddenly he will see a beauty of a breathtaking nature,
211 Socrates, the beauty which is the justification of all his efforts so far. It is eternal, neither coming to be nor passing away, neither increasing nor decreasing. Moreover it is not beautiful in part, and ugly in part, nor is it beautiful at one time, and not at another; nor beautiful in some respects, but not in others; nor beautiful here and ugly there, as if beautiful in some people's eyes, but not in others. It will not appear to him as the beauty of a face, or hands, or anything physical—nor as an idea or branch of knowledge, nor as existing in any determinate place, such as a living creature, or the earth, or heaven, or anywhere like that. It exists for all time, by
b itself and with itself, unique. All other forms of beauty derive from it, but in such a way that their creation or destruction does not strengthen or weaken it, or affect it in any way at all. If a man progresses (as he will do, if he goes about his love affairs in the right way) from the lesser beauties, and begins to catch sight of this beauty, then he is within reach of the final revelation. Such is the experience of the man who approaches, or is guided towards, love in the right way, beginning with
c the particular examples of beauty, but always returning from them to the search for that one beauty. He uses them like a ladder, climbing from the love of one person to love of two; from two to love of all physical beauty; from physical beauty to beauty in human behaviour; thence to beauty in subjects of study; from them he arrives finally at that branch of knowledge which studies nothing but ultimate beauty. Then at last he understands what true beauty is.

d "That, if ever, is the moment, my dear Socrates, when a man's life is worth living, as he contemplates beauty itself. Once seen, it will not seem to you to be a good such as gold, or fashionable clothes, or the boys and young men who have such an effect on you now when you see them. You, and any number of people like you, when you see your boyfriends and spend all your time with them, are quite prepared (or would be, if it were possible) to go without food and drink, just looking at them and being with them. But suppose it were granted to someone to see
e beauty itself quite clearly, in its pure, undiluted form—not clogged up with human flesh and colouring, and a whole lot of other worthless and corruptible matter. No,

imagine he were able to see the divine beauty itself in its unique essence. Don't you think he would find it a wonderful way to live, looking at it, contemplating 212
it as it should be contemplated, and spending his time in its company? It cannot fail to strike you that only then will it be possible for him, seeing beauty as it should be seen, to produce, not likenesses of goodness (since it is no likeness he has before him), but the real thing (since he has the real thing before him); and that this producing, and caring for, real goodness earns him the friendship of the gods and makes him, if anyone, immortal."

There you are, then, Phaedrus and the rest of you. That's what Diotima said to b
me, and I, for one, find it convincing. And it's because I'm convinced that I now try to persuade other people as well that man, in his search for this goal, could hardly hope to find a better ally than Eros. That's why I say that everyone should honour Eros, and why I myself honour him, and make the pursuit of Eros my chief concern, and encourage others to do the same. Now, and for all time, I praise the power and vigour of Eros, to the limits of my ability.

That's my speech, Phaedrus. You can take it, if you like, as a formal eulogy of c
Eros. Or you can call it by any other name you please.

This speech was greeted with applause, and Aristophanes started saying something about Socrates' reference to his speech, when suddenly there was a tremendous sound of hammering at the front door—people going home from a party, by the sound of it. You could hear the voice of a flute-girl.

AGATHON (to his slaves) Could you see who that is? If it's one of my friends, ask him in. Otherwise, say we've stopped drinking and are just going to bed. d

Almost at once we heard Alcibiades' voice from the courtyard. He was very drunk, and shouting at the top of his voice, asking "where Agathon was", and demanding "to be taken to Agathon". So in he came, supported by the girl, and some of his followers. He stood there in the doorway, wearing a luxuriant garland of ivy and violets, with his head covered in ribbons. e

ALCIBIADES Greetings, gentlemen. Will you allow me to join your gathering completely drunk? Or shall we just crown Agathon (which is what we've come

for) and go away? I couldn't come yesterday, but now here I am, with ribbons in my hair, so that I can take a garland from my own head, and crown the man whom I hereby proclaim the cleverest and handsomest man in Athens. Are you going to laugh at me for being drunk? Well, you may laugh, but I'm sure I'm right, all the
213 same. Anyway, those are my terms. So tell me right away: should I come in? Will you drink with me, or not?

Then everyone started talking at once, telling him to come in and sit down. And Agathon called him over. So over he came, assisted by his companions. He was taking off his ribbons, getting ready to put the garland on Agathon, and with the
b ribbons in front of his eyes he didn't see Socrates. So he sat down next to Agathon, between him and Socrates, Socrates moving aside, when he saw him, to make room. As he sat down he greeted Agathon, and put the garland on his head.

AGATHON (to his slaves) Take Alcibiades' shoes off. He can make a third at this table.

ALCIBIADES Excellent, but who is the other person drinking at our table? (Turning and seeing Socrates, and leaping to his feet) My God, what's this? Socrates here? You've been lying in wait here for me, just as you used to do. You were always
c turning up unexpectedly, wherever I least expected you. What are you doing here this time? And come to that, how've you managed to get yourself a place next to the most attractive person in the room? You ought to be next to someone like Aristophanes; he sets out to make himself ridiculous, and succeeds. Shouldn't you be with him?

d SOCRATES I'm going to need your protection, Agathon. I've found the love of this man a bit of a nightmare. From the day I took a fancy to him, I haven't been allowed to look at, or talk to, anyone attractive at all. If I do he gets envious and jealous, and starts behaving outrageously. He insults me, and can barely keep his hands off me. So you make sure he doesn't do anything now. You reconcile us, or defend me if he resorts to violence. His insane sexuality scares me stiff.

ALCIBIADES There can be no reconciliation between you and me. However,
e I'll get my revenge another time. For the moment, give me some of those ribbons,

Agathon, so I can make a garland for this remarkable head of his as well. I don't want him complaining that I crowned you, and not him, though he is the international grandmaster of words—and not just the day before yesterday, like you, but all the time. (As he said this he took some of the ribbons, made a garland for Socrates, and sat down.) Well, gentlemen, you seem to me to be pretty sober. We can't have that. You'll have to drink. After all, that's what we agreed. So I'm going to choose a Master of Ceremonies, to see you all get enough to drink. I choose myself. Agathon, let them bring a large cup, if you've got one. No, wait! (Suddenly catching sight of an ice-bucket holding upwards of half a gallon.) No need for that. Boy, bring me that ice-bucket. (He filled it, and started off by draining it himself. Then he told the 214
slave to fill it up again for Socrates.) A useless ploy against Socrates, gentlemen. It doesn't matter how much you give him to drink, he'll drink it and be none the worse for wear. (So the slave filled the bucket for Socrates, who drank it.)

ERYXIMACHUS What's the plan, Alcibiades? Are we just going to sit here and drink as if we were dying of thirst? Aren't we going to talk, or sing, at all while b
we drink?

ALCIBIADES Ah, Eryximachus. Most excellent scion of a most excellent and sensible father. Good evening.

ERYXIMACHUS Good evening to you too. But what *do* you want us to do?

ALCIBIADES Whatever you recommend. We must do as you say. After all, "a doctor is worth a dozen ordinary men". So you tell us your prescription.

ERYXIMACHUS Very well, listen. We had decided, before you came, that going round anticlockwise, each of us in turn should make the best speech he could about c
Eros, in praise of him. We've all made our speeches. You've drunk but you haven't spoken. So it's only fair that you should speak now; after that you can give any instructions you like to Socrates, and he can do the same to the man on his right, and so on all the way round.

ALCIBIADES That's a good idea, Eryximachus. But it's grossly unfair to ask me, drunk, to compete with you sober. Also, my dear friend, I hope you didn't pay any

d attention to Socrates' remarks just now. Presumably you realise the situation is the exact opposite of what he said. He's the one who will resort to violence, if I praise anyone else, god or man, in his presence.

SOCRATES Can't you hold your tongue?

ALCIBIADES Don't worry, I wouldn't dream of praising anyone else if you're here.

ERYXIMACHUS Well, that'll do, if you like. Praise Socrates.

e ALCIBIADES Really? You think I should, Eryximachus? Shall I set about him, and get my own back on him, here in front of you all?

SOCRATES Hey! What are you up to? Are you trying to make a fool of me by praising me? Or what?

ALCIBIADES I'm going to tell the truth. Do you mind that?

SOCRATES Of course not. In fact, I'm all in favour of it.

ALCIBIADES I can't wait to start. And here's what you can do. If I say anything
215 that's not true, you can interrupt me, if you like, and tell me I'm wrong. I shan't get anything wrong on purpose, but don't be surprised if my recollection of things is a bit higgledy-piggledy. It's not easy, when you're as drunk as I am, to give a clear and orderly account of someone as strange as you.

ALCIBIADES

Gentlemen, I'm going to try and praise Socrates using similes. He may think I'm trying to make a fool of him, but the point of the simile is its accuracy, not its
b absurdity. I think he's very like one of those Silenus-figures sculptors have on their shelves. They're made with flutes or pipes. You can open them up, and when you

do you find little figures of the gods inside. I also think Socrates is like the satyr Marsyas. As far as your appearance goes, Socrates, even you can't claim these are poor comparisons; but I'll tell you how the likeness holds good in other ways: just listen. You're a troublemaker, aren't you? Don't deny it, I can bring witnesses. You may not play the pipes, like Marsyas, but what you do is much more amazing. He c had only to open his mouth to delight men, but he needed a musical instrument to do it. The same goes for anyone nowadays who plays his music—I count what Olympus played as really Marsyas', since he learnt from him. His is the only music which carries people away, and reveals those who have a desire for the gods and their rites. Such is its divine power, and it makes no difference whether it's played by an expert, or by a mere flute-girl.

You have the same effect on people. The only difference is that you do it with words alone, without the aid of any instrument. We can all listen to anyone else d talking, and it has virtually no effect on us, no matter what he's talking about, or how good a speaker he is. But when we listen to you, or to someone else using your arguments, even if he's a hopeless speaker, we're overwhelmed and carried away. This is true of men, women and children alike.

For my own part, gentlemen, I would like to tell you on my honour (only you would certainly think I was drunk) the effect what he says has had on me in e the past—and still does have, to this day. When I hear him, it's like the worst kind of religious hysteria. My heart pounds, and I find myself in floods of tears, such is the effect of his words. And I can tell lots of other people feel the same. I used to listen to Pericles and other powerful speakers, and I thought they spoke well. But they never had the effect on me of turning all my beliefs upside down, with the disturbing realisation that my whole life is that of a slave. Whereas this Marsyas 216 here has often made me feel that, and decide that the kind of life I lead is just not worth living. You can't deny it, Socrates.

Even now I know in my heart of hearts that if I were to listen to him, I couldn't resist him. The same thing would happen again. He forces me to admit that with all my faults I do nothing to improve myself, but continue in public life just the same. b So I tear myself away, as if stopping my ears against the Sirens; otherwise I would spend my whole life there sitting at his feet. He's the only man who can appeal to my better nature (not that most people would reckon I *had* a better nature), because I'm only too aware I have no answer to his arguments. I know I should do as he

tells me, but when I leave him I have no defence against my own ambition and desire for recognition. So I run for my life, and avoid him, and when I see him, c I'm embarrassed, when I remember conclusions we've reached in the past. I would often cheerfully have seen him dead, and yet I know that if that did happen, I should be even more upset. So I just can't cope with the man.

I'm by no means the only person to be affected like this by his satyr's music, but that isn't all I have to say about his similarity to those figures I likened him to, and about his remarkable powers. Believe me, none of you really knows the man. d So I'll enlighten you, now that I've begun.

Your view of Socrates is of someone who fancies attractive men, spends all his time with them, finds them irresistible—and you know how hopelessly ignorant and uncertain he is. And yet this pose is extremely Silenus-like. It's the outward mask he wears, like the carved Silenus. Open him up, and he's a model of restraint—you wouldn't believe it, my dear fellow-drinkers. Take my word for it, it makes no difference at all how attractive you are, he has an astonishing contempt for that kind e of thing. Similarly with riches, or any of the other so-called advantages we possess. He regards all possessions as worthless, and us humans as insignificant. No, I mean it—he treats his whole life in human society as a game or puzzle.

But when he's serious, when he opens up and you see the real Socrates—I don't know if any of you has ever seen the figure inside. I saw it once, and it struck me as utterly godlike and golden and beautiful and wonderful. In fact, I thought I must simply do anything he told me. And since I thought he was serious about 217 my good looks, I congratulated myself on a fantastic stroke of luck, which had given me the chance to satisfy Socrates, and be the recipient, in return, of all his knowledge. I had, I may say, an extremely high opinion of my own looks.

That was my plan, so I did what I had never done up to then—I sent away b my attendant, and took to seeing him on my own. You see, I'm going to tell you the whole truth, so listen carefully, and you tell them, Socrates, if I get anything wrong. Well, gentlemen, I started seeing him—just the two of us—and I thought he would start talking to me as lovers do to their boyfriends when they're alone together. I was very excited. But nothing like that happened at all. He spent the day talking to c me as usual, and then left. I invited him to the gymnasium with me, and exercised with him there, thinking I might make some progress that way. So he exercised and wrestled with me, often completely on our own, and (needless to say) it got

me nowhere at all. When that turned out to be no good, I thought I'd better make a pretty determined assault on the man, and not give up, now that I'd started. I wanted to find out what the trouble was. So I asked him to dinner, just like a lover with designs on his boyfriend.

He took some time to agree even to this, but finally I did get him to come. d The first time he came, he had dinner, and then got up to go. I lost my nerve, that time, and let him go. But I decided to try again. He came to dinner, and I kept him talking late into the night. When he tried to go home, I made him stay, saying it was too late to go. So he stayed the night on the couch next to mine. There was no one else sleeping in the room.

What I've told you so far I'd be quite happy to repeat to anyone. The next part e I'm only telling you because (a) I'm drunk—"in vino veritas", and all that—and (b) since I've started praising Socrates, it seems wrong to leave out an example of his superior behaviour. Besides, I'm like someone who's been bitten by an adder. They say that a man who's had this happen to him will only say what it was like to others who've been bitten; they're the only people who will understand, and make 218 allowances for, his willingness to say or do anything, such is the pain. Well, I've been bitten by something worse than an adder, and in the worst possible place. I've been stung, or bitten, in my heart or soul (whatever you care to call it) by a method of philosophical argument, whose bite, when it gets a grip on a young and intelligent mind, is sharper than any adder's. It makes one willing to say or do anything. I can see all these Phaedruses and Agathons, Eryximachuses, Pausaniases, b Aristodemuses and Aristophaneses here, not to mention Socrates himself and the rest of you. You've all had a taste of this wild passion for philosophy, so you'll understand me, and forgive what I did then, and what I'm telling you now. As for the servants, and anyone else who's easily shocked, or doesn't know what I'm talking about, they'll just have to put something over their ears.

There we were, then, gentlemen. The lamp had gone out, the slaves had gone to bed. I decided it was time to abandon subtlety, and say plainly what I was after. c So I nudged him. "Socrates, are you asleep?" "No." "Do you know what I've decided?" "What?" "I think you're the ideal person to be my lover, but you seem to be a bit shy about suggesting it. So I'll tell you how I feel about it. I think I'd be crazy not to satisfy you in this way, just as I'd do anything else for you if it was in my power—or in my friends' power. Nothing matters more to me than my own d

improvement, and I can't imagine a better helper than you. Anyone with any sense would think worse of me for not giving a man like you what he wants than most ignorant people would if I did give you what you want."

Socrates listened to this. Then, with characteristic irony, he replied. "My dear
e Alcibiades, you're certainly nobody's fool, if you're right in what you say about me, and I do have some power to improve you. It must be remarkable beauty you see in me, far superior to your own physical beauty. If that's the aim of your deal with me, to exchange beauty for beauty, then you're trying to get much the better of the bargain. You want to get real beauty in exchange for what is commonly mistaken for it, like Diomedes getting gold armour in return for his bronze. Better think
219 again, however. You might be wrong about me. Judgment begins when eyesight starts to fail, and you're still a long way from that."

I listened, then said: "Well, as far as I am concerned, that's how things stand.
b I've told you my real feelings. You must decide what you think best for yourself and for me." "That's good advice. We must think about it some time, and act as seems best to us, in this matter as in others."

After this exchange, thinking my direct assault had made some impact, I got up, before he could say anything more, wrapped my cloak around him (it was winter), and lay down with him under his rough cloak. I put my arms round him.
c I spent the whole night with him, remarkable, superhuman being that he is—still telling the truth, Socrates, you can't deny it—but he was more than equal to my advances. He rejected them, laughed at my good looks, and treated them with contempt; and I must admit that, as far as looks went, I thought I was quite something, members of the jury. (I call you that, since I'm accusing Socrates of contempt.) In short, I promise you faithfully, I fell asleep, and when I woke up in the morning I'd slept with Socrates all night, but absolutely nothing had happened.
d It was just like sleeping with one's father or elder brother.

Imagine how I felt after that. I was humiliated and yet full of admiration for Socrates' character—his restraint and strength of mind. I'd met a man whose equal, in intelligence and control, I didn't think I should ever meet again. I couldn't have
e a row with him; that would just lose me his friendship. Nor could I see any way of attracting him. I knew money would make as little impression on him as Trojan weapons on Ajax, and he'd already escaped my one sure means of ensnaring him. I didn't know what to do, and I went around infatuated with the man. No one's ever been so infatuated.

That was the background to our military service together in Potidaea, where we were messmates. In the first place there was his toughness—not only greater than mine, but greater than anyone else's. Sometimes we were cut off and had to go without food, as happens on campaign. No one could match him for endurance. 220
On the other hand, he was the one who really made the most of it when there was plenty. He wouldn't drink for choice, but if he had to, he drank us all under the table. Surprising as it may seem, no man has ever seen Socrates drunk. I've no doubt you'll see confirmation of that this evening. As for the weather (they have pretty savage winters up there), his indifference to it was always astonishing, but one occasion stands out in particular. There was an incredibly severe frost. No one
b went outside, or if they did, they went muffled up to the eyeballs, with their feet wrapped up in wool or sheepskin. In these conditions Socrates went out in the same cloak he always wore, and walked barefoot over the ice with less fuss than the rest of us who had our feet wrapped up. The men didn't like it at all; they thought he
c was getting at them.

So much for that. But there's another exploit of this"conquering hero" during that campaign, which I ought to tell you about. He was studying a problem one morning, and he stood there thinking about it, not making any progress, but not giving up either—just standing there, trying to find the answer. By midday people were beginning to take notice, and remark to one another in some surprise that Socrates had been standing there thinking since dawn. Finally, in the evening after supper, some of the Ionians brought out their mattresses (this was in summer), and slept in the open, keeping an eye on him to see if he'd stand there all night. And
d sure enough he did stand there, until dawn broke and the sun rose. Then he said a prayer to the sun and left.

Should I say something about his conduct in action? Yes, I think he's earned it. In the battle in which the generals gave me a decoration, my own life was saved
e by none other than Socrates. He refused to leave me when I was wounded, and saved both me and my weapons. So I recommended that the generals should give you the decoration. Isn't that true, Socrates? You can't object to that, or say I'm lying, can you? In fact the generals were inclined to favour me, because of my social position, and wanted to give it to me, but you were keener than they were that I should get it, rather than you.

And you should have seen him, gentlemen, on the retreat from Delium. I was with him, but I was on horseback, and he was on foot. He was retreating, 221

amid the general rout, with Laches. I came upon them, and when I saw them I told them not to panic, and said I'd stick by them. This time I got a better view of Socrates than I had at Potidaea, since I was on horseback, and less worried about
b my own safety. For a start, he was much more composed than Laches. And then I thought your description of him, Aristophanes, was as accurate there as it is here in Athens, "marching along with his head in the air, staring at all around him", calmly contemplating friend and foe alike. It was perfectly clear, even from a distance, that any attempt to lay a finger on him would arouse vigorous resistance. So he and his
c companion escaped unhurt. On the whole, in battle, you don't meddle with people like that. You go after the ones in headlong flight.

I could go on praising Socrates all night, and tell you some surprising things. Many of his qualities can be found in other people, and yet it's remarkable how unlike he is to anyone in the past or present. You can compare Brasidas, or someone
d like that, with Achilles; Pericles with Nestor or Antenor (for example); and make other similar comparisons. But you could go a long way and not find a match, dead or living, for Socrates. So unusual are the man himself and his arguments. You have to go back to my original comparison of the man and his arguments, to Silenuses and satyrs. I didn't say this at the beginning, but his arguments, when you really look at them, are also just like Silenus-figures. If you decided to listen to one, it would
e strike you at first as ludicrous. On the face of it, it's just a collection of irrelevant words and phrases; but those are just the outer skin of this trouble-making satyr. It's all donkeys and bronzesmiths, shoemakers and tanners. He always seems to be repeating himself, and people who haven't heard him before, and aren't too quick
222 on the uptake, laugh at what he says. But look beneath the surface, and get inside them, and you'll find two things. In the first place, they're the only arguments which really make any sense; on top of that they are supremely inspiring, because they contain countless models of excellence and pointers towards it. In fact, they deal with everything you should be concerned about, if you want to lead a good and noble life.

That's my speech, gentlemen, in praise of Socrates—though I've included
b a bit of blame as well for his outrageous treatment of me. And I'm not the only sufferer. There's Charmides, the son of Glaucon, and Euthydemus, the son of Diocles, and lots of others. He seduces them, like a lover seducing his boyfriend,

and then it turns out he's not their lover at all; in fact, they're his lovers. So take my advice, Agathon, and don't be seduced. Learn from our experience, rather than at first hand, like Homer's "fool who learnt too late". Don't trust him an inch.

Alcibiades' candour aroused some amusement. He seemed to be still in love c with Socrates.

SOCRATES Not so drunk after all, Alcibiades; or you wouldn't have avoided, so elegantly and so deviously, revealing the real object of your speech, just slipping it in at the end, as if it were an afterthought. What you're really trying to do is turn Agathon and me against one another. You think that I should be your lover, and d no one else's; and that you, and no one else, should be Agathon's. Well, it hasn't worked. All that stuff about satyrs and Silenuses is quite transparent. You mustn't let him get away with it, my dear Agathon; you must make sure no one turns us against each other.

AGATHON You may be right, Socrates. His sitting between us, to keep us apart, bears that out. But it won't work. I'll come round and sit next to you. e

SOCRATES Good idea. Sit here, round this side.

ALCIBIADES Ye gods. What I have to put up with from the man. He has to keep scoring off me. Look, at least let Agathon sit in the middle.

SOCRATES Out of the question. You've just praised me, and now I must praise the person on my right. If Agathon sits next to you, he can't be expected to make *another* speech in praise of me. I'd better make one in praise of him instead. No, you'll have to admit defeat, my good friend, and put up with me praising the boy. 223 I look forward to it.

AGATHON What a bit of luck. I'm certainly not staying here, Alcibiades. I'd much rather move, and get myself praised by Socrates.

ALCIBIADES That's it, the same old story. Whenever Socrates is around, no one else can get near anyone good-looking. Like now, for example. Look how easily he finds plausible reasons why Agathon should sit next to him.

b Agathon got up to come and sit by Socrates. Suddenly a whole crowd of people on their way home from a party turned up at the door, and finding it open (someone was just leaving), they came straight in, and sat down to join us. Things became incredibly noisy and disorderly, and we couldn't avoid having far too much to drink. Eryximachus and Phaedrus and some others went home. I fell asleep, and slept for
c some time, the nights being long at that time of year. When I woke up it was almost light, and the cocks were crowing. I could see that everyone had gone home or to sleep, apart from Agathon, Aristophanes, and Socrates. They were still awake and drinking (passing a large bowl round anticlockwise). Socrates was holding the floor.
d I've forgotten most of what he was saying, since I missed the beginning of it, and was still half-asleep anyway. The gist of it was that he was forcing them to admit that the same man could be capable of writing comedy and tragedy, and hence that a successful tragedian must also be able to write comedy. As they were being driven to this conclusion, though not really following the argument, they dropped off. Aristophanes went to sleep first, and then, as it was getting light, Agathon. Socrates made them both comfortable, and got up to leave himself. I followed him, as usual. He went to the Lyceum, had a bath, spent the rest of the day as he normally would, and then, towards evening, went home to bed.